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FREE RESEARCH GUIDE

The Clean Label *Saboteur* Guide.

The 6 ingredients hiding in your fitness supplements that are working against your gut — and the exact label criteria for a clean stack.

THE PROBLEM

Your stack is working against your gut.

You train hard. You track your macros. You've invested in a serious supplement stack. And you're still bloating after every protein shake, every pre-workout, every "clean" meal.

The fitness industry has a dirty secret: most of the ingredients that make supplements taste good and mix well are the exact same ingredients that disrupt the gut microbiome.

87%

OF FLAVORED PRE-WORKOUTS
CONTAIN AT LEAST ONE GUT-
DISRUPTING SWEETENER

64%

OF PROTEIN BARS CONTAIN
SUGAR ALCOHOLS LINKED TO
OSMOTIC BLOATING

50%

REDUCTION IN LACTOBACILLUS
COUNTS OBSERVED WITH
REGULAR SUCRALOSE USE

"Your gut is reacting exactly as it should to ingredients it was never designed to process. This is a chemistry problem — not a discipline failure."

The following pages identify the six most common gut-disrupting ingredients found in mainstream fitness supplements — where they hide, what they do, and what to look for on a label instead.

THE SABOTEUR LIST

6 ingredients to eliminate.

● Sucralose

Found in: C4, Ghost, Celsius, most flavored pre-workouts

Shown to reduce beneficial *Lactobacillus* populations by up to 50% at standard serving sizes. Alters gut pH and promotes growth of opportunistic bacteria. The most common cause of post-supplement bloating in athletic women.

● Acesulfame Potassium (Ace-K)

Found in: Reign, Bang, most RTD protein shakes, diet sodas

Linked to gut microbiome disruption and increased intestinal permeability ("leaky gut"). Often paired with sucralose for synergistic sweetness — doubling the gut impact. Difficult to identify because it can be listed under multiple names.

● Sugar Alcohols (Sorbitol, Maltitol, Xylitol, Erythritol)

Found in: Quest bars, RXBar flavored varieties, most low-carb protein bars

Incompletely absorbed in the small intestine, then rapidly fermented by gut bacteria in the colon. This fermentation produces hydrogen and methane gas, causing severe osmotic bloating and distension — often within 30–90 minutes of consumption.

● Whey Concentrate

Found in: Most budget whey proteins, mass gainers, flavored protein blends

Unlike whey isolate, concentrate retains significant lactose content. Even mild lactose sensitivity — present in roughly 65% of adult women — triggers bloating and GI distress at the 25g+ serving sizes common in post-workout shakes. Look for "whey isolate" specifically.

● Inulin / Chicory Root (High Dose)

Found in: AG1, Bloom Greens, most fiber-added greens powders

A prebiotic fiber that can be beneficial in small doses but ferments aggressively in the colon at the 5–10g doses common in greens powders. Causes pronounced gas and abdominal distension, particularly when combined with a high-protein diet.

- **Carrageenan**

Found in: Some RTD protein shakes, plant-based milks used as shake bases

A processed seaweed extract used as a thickener and emulsifier. Classified as a gut inflammatory agent in multiple peer-reviewed studies. Linked to increased intestinal permeability and inflammatory bowel symptoms at regular dietary exposure.

THE CLEAN LABEL CHECKLIST

What a clean stack looks like.

Use this checklist when auditing your current supplements. A clean label passes all six criteria.

**Whey Isolate (not Concentrate)**

Lactose removed. Safe for sensitive guts at any protein dose.

**Stevia or Monk Fruit only**

The only non-nutritive sweeteners without documented microbiome disruption at normal doses.

**No sugar alcohols on the label**

Check for: sorbitol, maltitol, xylitol, erythritol, mannitol, lactitol.

**Under 3g added fiber per serving**

Above this threshold, especially with inulin/chicory root, fermentation bloat becomes likely.

**No "proprietary blend" on the label**

Proprietary blends hide ingredient doses — you can't verify what you're actually consuming.

**No carrageenan or guar gum as primary thickener**

Common in RTD shakes. Xanthan gum at low doses is generally well-tolerated.

THE NEXT STEP

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